Who Would Handle the Letters?

A family conversation about Dad's paperwork, with Dad in the room.

Dad has always done his own paperwork, and he's good at it. Nobody has ever asked him who he'd want opening the mail if he wanted a hand someday.

This guide is for one unhurried conversation with one job: hear Dad's answer and write it down, along with what each of you already knows. It isn't for deciding anything about his money, and nothing has to change afterward.

Who should be there

Dad, first. It's his paperwork and his choice, and this conversation doesn't happen without him. If he has a spouse or partner, they belong at the table too. Then the family members who already help with anything, or would be willing to: the one who lives nearby, the one who is good with forms, the one who lives far away and phones on Sundays. Someone who can't come can send a note ahead.

Pick one person to take notes. It shouldn't be the person leading the conversation.

How to open

Start with what Dad already does well, and with a question, not a plan.

- “Dad, you've always handled your own paperwork, and nobody wants to take it over. We'd just like to know how you'd want things done if you ever wanted a hand.”
- “None of us could say where things are kept, or who you'd want us to call. Could we write that down, in your words?”
- Say what the conversation is for: knowing Dad's wishes and who would do what. Say what it isn't for: deciding anything about his money or his home, or working out whether he'll ever need Medicaid.
- If he'd rather not today, leave the page with him and pick another day.

Questions to ask

Ask Dad

1. If you ever wanted a hand with the mail and the paperwork, who would you want doing it?

2. Where do you keep your statements, receipts and important papers, and who besides you knows?

3. How do you keep track of your accounts now, and is there a part of it you'd like one of us to learn from you?

4. Who do you already call with a money or legal question, and would you want us to have their numbers?

Ask each other

1. Who is willing to be the person Dad named, and who would back them up?

2. What does each of us already help with, or already know, about Dad's paperwork?

3. If something changed for Dad, such as a move, a sale or money arriving, who would write it down and take the question to a professional before anyone acts?

4. When will we look at this again, and what don't any of us know yet?

How to write down what was said

Put Dad's answers at the top, in his own words. Where two people remember something differently, write both and don't settle it at the table. If a job has no name beside it yet, leave it blank instead of volunteering someone who isn't in the room.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	WHAT IT'S ABOUT	REMEMBERED DIFFERENTLY BY
“If I ever want help with the mail, I'd want Karen. She's the careful one.”	Dad	Who would handle the mail	
The insurance papers are in the hall closet.	David	Where records are kept	Dad says the roll-top desk

Questions to carry out of the room

Nobody at the table has to know these answers. Write them down as they are, for the day you sit down with your Medicaid planner or call the Medicaid agency.

- What does a family have to do after Medicaid approves a parent?
- What changes would we need to report?
- Could a parent lose Medicaid after being approved?

What not to decide yet

These wait for the right professional, or for a look in the desk with Dad. Leave them open.

- Whether Dad will ever need Medicaid, or when.
- What to do with any account, his home or anything else he owns.
- What it would take to make Dad's choice official. That's a question for an elder law attorney.
- Who was right about where something is kept.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the notes and send them to everyone, Dad included.
- Who will go through the records with Dad, on a day that suits him.
- When you'll talk again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, decide anything about Dad's money or his legal documents, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets Dad's own answer onto one page, with the open questions left on it. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has talked about who would handle what, and Dad's own answer is on paper. The planning interview asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring, with your notes, to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›